

Reading skill and the time course of morphological processing: electrophysiological evidence for stage-specific modulation

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2 ABSTRACT

3 Skilled reading of morphologically complex words depends on both high-quality lexical
4 representations and sensitivity to morphological structure. However, we do not yet understand
5 how these abilities shape the time course of morphological processing. In this study, event-
6 related potentials (ERPs) and reaction times were recorded during a lexical decision task on
7 morphologically complex words and nonwords; both varied in base frequency and family size, and
8 nonwords additionally varied in morphological complexity. Individual differences were quantified
9 via principal components analysis of vocabulary knowledge, spelling ability, and print exposure,
10 yielding two orthogonal dimensions: Language Proficiency (LP) and Orthographic Sensitivity
11 (OS). Behaviourally, response times were sensitive to base frequency and family size for words,
12 and to morphological complexity for nonwords, while individual differences played a minor role:
13 Orthographic Sensitivity showed a modest effect on response speed for nonwords only, and
14 Language Proficiency showed no reliable effect. ERP measures revealed a richer picture. For
15 familiar words, Orthographic Sensitivity selectively modulated the N250 base frequency effect,
16 while Language Proficiency modulated the N400 base frequency effect, consistent with a form-to-
17 meaning dissociation. For novel morphologically complex forms, both Orthographic Sensitivity
18 and Language Proficiency modulated the cost of morphological complexity at the N250. For both
19 dimensions, the complexity cost shrank as skill increased and reversed direction at the highest

skill levels. Because both dimensions were involved, this pattern qualifies the prediction that Orthographic Sensitivity alone governs early morphological parsing: instead, early parsing of novel forms appears to draw on reading skill more broadly. At the N400, a large morphological family made complex nonwords harder to process for readers lower in Language Proficiency, but this cost was absent for readers higher in Language Proficiency; Orthographic Sensitivity showed no comparable effect, giving the clearest evidence for the predicted dissociation between the two dimensions. Together these findings indicate that individual differences in reading skill are expressed chiefly in the dynamics of neural processing rather than in overt response times, and that the dissociation between orthographic and lexical-semantic profiles is clearest at the later stage where word meaning is accessed, while early morphological parsing of novel forms depends on both dimensions.

Keywords: morphological processing, individual differences, event-related potentials, N250, N400, lexical decision

1 INTRODUCTION

Reading is often described as "the process of gaining meaning from print" (Rayner et al., 2001, p. 34). Although comprehension ultimately depends on sentence- and discourse-level integration, efficient access to individual word forms and meanings remains a foundational component of skilled reading. However, readers vary considerably in this ability (Perfetti, 2007; Castles and Nation, 2006; Stanovich and West, 1989). Understanding what drives this variation requires identifying variables that are selectively diagnostic of the mechanisms underlying word recognition. Two such variables, base frequency (also referred to as stem frequency in the literature) and morphological family size, have proven especially informative for this purpose (Taft, 2004, 1979; de Jong et al., 2000; Bertram et al., 2000). Base frequency, the cumulative token frequency of a base morpheme across all its surface forms, and morphological family size, the number of distinct words sharing that base, both facilitate visual word recognition, yet their effects are independent and have been argued to reflect different levels of morphological representation: base frequency has been argued to index form-based access, reflecting the cumulative ease with which a base morpheme's orthographic form is processed across its surface variants, while family size has been argued to index the richness of semantic representation, reflecting the breadth of meaning-level connections activated when a morphological base is encountered (Schreuder and Baayen, 1997). The present study exploits this dissociation to ask how readers who differ in the precision of their orthographic and semantic knowledge draw differentially on form-based and meaning-based information during morphological processing.

Both variables are properties of a word's morphological family, and morphological structure plays a particularly important role in the English writing system. English exhibits irregular and context-sensitive grapheme–phoneme mappings, rendering phonological decoding alone an insufficient basis for fluent word recognition (Ziegler and Goswami, 2005; Castles and Nation, 2006). At the same time, English preserves regularities at higher representational levels, particularly in its morphological structure; words that share a stem or affix often exhibit consistent orthographic patterns and systematic semantic relationships (e.g., *heal*–*health* share a stem; *teacher*, *baker*, and *driver* share the agentive suffix *-er*). Skilled reading in English therefore requires sensitivity not only to phonological correspondences but also to recurring morphological structure that links form and meaning, and readers differ in how deeply and precisely that structure is represented (Bryant et al., 2005; Arciuli, 2018; Treiman, 2018).

Base frequency and family size are the primary variables used to study this structural sensitivity; before characterising how readers differ in processing them, however, it is necessary to clarify what each variable

indexes and how it has been theoretically interpreted. This question has proven theoretically contentious because the answer depends on the architecture one ascribes to the word recognition system. Whether skilled readers decompose complex words into constituent morphemes, access whole-word representations directly, or exploit learned statistical regularities carries different implications for what each variable measures, that is, whether it reflects the strength of a stored morpheme entry, the output of a parsing procedure, or an emergent property of a statistical learning system. As a result, what each variable measures determines what kind of reader variation should modulate its effect. The Lexical Quality Hypothesis (Perfetti and Hart, 2002; Perfetti, 2007, 2017) provides a principled framework for characterising that variation: lexical representations vary across readers in how completely and precisely a word's orthographic and semantic constituents are specified, and it is this variation in representational quality that determines how strongly each variable influences processing. Although competing architectures disagree about the mechanism responsible, they converge in treating base frequency as an index of how precisely the orthographic form of the base morpheme is specified, and family size as an index of how richly and flexibly its meaning is represented across morphological contexts. Readers who differ in orthographic precision versus semantic breadth should therefore differ selectively in their sensitivity to each variable.

1.1 Base Frequency, Morphological Family Size, and Competing Theoretical Accounts

Both base frequency and morphological family size facilitate visual word recognition, and their effects are independent when appropriately controlled (Ford et al., 2010). The theoretical significance of this dissociation is that it constrains what any model of morphological processing must explain: current accounts converge on the prediction that base frequency effects arise earlier in processing than family size effects, but diverge sharply in the mechanisms responsible.

Dual-route and multi-stage accounts agree that the two variables index distinct levels of processing, but disagree on the nature of those levels. In classical dual-route frameworks (Schreuder and Baayen, 1995; de Jong et al., 2000), base frequency reflects the ease of accessing a stored morpheme entry via a decompositional route, while family size reflects the richness of the semantic network surrounding the base, attributed to the whole-form route. Early automatic decomposition accounts (Taft and Forster, 1975; Taft, 2004) reconceptualise this dissociation in temporal rather than architectural terms: decomposition is not one route among several but an obligatory initial parsing step that precedes semantic access. On the morpho-orthographic formulation of this view (Rastle and Davis, 2008; Longtin and Meunier, 2005; Morris et al., 2007), an intermediate level of representation mediates between sublexical letter clusters and whole-word forms, and base frequency reflects the strength of activation at this stage. Family size effects are then linked to later semantic processing, consistent with the finding that opaque relatives contribute less to the family size effect than transparent ones (Schreuder and Baayen, 1997; de Jong et al., 2000).

The discriminative learning framework (NDL/LDL; Chuang and Baayen, 2021) offers a more radical reinterpretation. On this account, lexical processing is modelled as learned form-to-meaning mappings driven by prediction error rather than by decompositional morpheme retrieval. Base frequency reflects the accumulated strength of the *n*-gram cues that spell out the base across all its surface forms, while family size reflects the type diversity of the training signal; a larger family causes shared cues to converge on a more robustly specified semantic core. Both effects arise from the same learning mechanism, rendering the dissociation between them a consequence of different statistical properties of the input rather than evidence for distinct representational levels or processing routes.

Taken together, these accounts agree that base frequency and family size exert independent effects, with base frequency arising earlier in processing than family size. Where they diverge is in the nature of

the representations involved—symbolic morpheme entries, learned orthographic patterns, or weighted form-to-meaning mappings—and consequently in how they explain the source of individual differences in sensitivity to each variable. Dual-route and morpho-orthographic accounts imply that readers with more precise sublexical orthographic representations should show greater sensitivity to base frequency, since this variable indexes activation strength at the form-parsing stage, while readers with richer semantic networks should show greater sensitivity to family size, since this variable indexes the breadth of meaning-level connectivity. The discriminative learning framework leads to a similar expectation but for different reasons: individual differences in statistical learning history determine the specificity of both orthographic cue weights and semantic vectors, so readers with more extensive print exposure should show stronger and more differentiated sensitivity to both variables. However, all three accounts are consistent with the view that form-level and meaning-level sensitivity should be dissociable, and that this dissociation should be traceable to distinct processing stages—early for base frequency, later for family size.

Across these accounts, a recurring question is whether morphological decomposition is driven primarily by affix recognition or by stem activation. Affix-stripping accounts (Taft and Forster, 1975; Rastle and Davis, 2008) propose that the affix is identified first and triggers decomposition, after which the stem is looked up in the lexicon. However, Beyersmann et al. (2016) found that high proficiency readers showed embedded stem priming effects independent of affix status: priming occurred even when the stem was followed by a non-affixal ending, suggesting that stem activation in skilled readers is not contingent on affix recognition. This finding suggests that affix-stripping alone may be insufficient to account for morphological processing in skilled readers, and raises the possibility that stem- and affix-based mechanisms operate concurrently, with their relative contributions varying as a function of individual differences in reading proficiency. The present study tests this possibility directly by examining whether Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency, two dissociable dimensions of individual variation in reading skill, differentially modulate early morpho-orthographic parsing in ways consistent with affix-based and stem-based mechanisms respectively.

1.2 Individual Differences in Morphological Processing

Traditional models of word recognition have typically characterised processing at the level of the skilled reader in general, abstracting over individual differences in favour of a uniform cognitive architecture. Yet readers vary considerably in how they process written words, and understanding this variation offers a window into the representations and processes underlying skilled reading. The Lexical Quality Hypothesis, introduced above, provides a principled framework for understanding this variation. Readers do not differ along a single dimension of lexical quality. Andrews and colleagues (Andrews, 2012; Andrews and Lo, 2013) have demonstrated that individual differences in orthographic and semantic knowledge are dissociable and predict distinct patterns of morphological processing. Readers with a semantic profile, defined by relatively higher vocabulary than spelling ability, show robust priming for transparent morphological pairs but little priming for opaque or form-only pairs, particularly for slower responses. Readers with an orthographic profile, defined by relatively higher spelling than vocabulary, show sustained priming for opaque pairs that is at least as strong as for transparent pairs. Andrews and Lo (2013) interpret this pattern as evidence that a systematic component of individual differences among skilled readers is explicable in terms of the balance between orthographic and semantic processing; readers differ not merely in overall processing efficiency but in the relative weight they assign to form-based versus meaning-based information during lexical access.

The present study builds directly on this finding. If base frequency and family size index form-based and meaning-based aspects of lexical representation respectively, then readers who differ in their balance

of orthographic and semantic processing should differ predictably in their sensitivity to each variable. Moreover, if these differences have a temporal structure, with form-based processing preceding semantic processing in the recognition cascade, they should be traceable to distinct ERP components. To capture the full range of this variation continuously rather than as a categorical split, the present study derives two orthogonal individual difference dimensions, Language Proficiency and Orthographic Sensitivity, from a principal components analysis of vocabulary knowledge, spelling ability, and print exposure, following the approach of Andrews and Lo (2013). If base frequency and family size are differentially modulated by these two dimensions, and if those modulations emerge at distinct stages in the ERP, this would constitute direct electrophysiological evidence that orthographic and semantic processing represent a genuine and temporally structured axis of variation in the human reading system.

1.3 Neural Indices of Morphological Processing

To track whether base frequency and family size effects emerge at distinct temporal stages, and whether individual differences in orthographic and semantic processing modulate those stages selectively, the present study uses two well-established ERP components as dependent measures—the N250, as an index of sublexical processing, and the N400, as an index of lexical-semantic integration. These components have been argued to reflect sequential stages in the cascade from orthographic decoding to meaning retrieval during visual word recognition (Grainger and Holcomb, 2009).

The N250 is a negative-going deflection peaking at approximately 250 ms post-stimulus onset. Holcomb and Grainger (2006) propose that it reflects the stage at which abstract sublexical orthographic representations, that is letters and letter clusters, are mapped onto higher-level form representations prior to full lexical access. Evidence for this interpretation comes from its graded sensitivity to orthographic overlap between prime and target in masked priming; N250 amplitude is most attenuated for full identity repetitions, intermediate for primes sharing all but one letter, and largest for fully unrelated pairs (Holcomb and Grainger, 2006, 2007). The N250 is also sensitive to sublexical phonological overlap, with Grainger et al. (2006) identifying separable early orthographic and later phonological subcomponents, consistent with dual-route architectures of word recognition.

The N400 is a negative-going component peaking around 400 ms, with a broad centro-parietal distribution (Kutas and Hillyard, 1980). Across more than four decades of research, its amplitude has been shown to vary with semantic priming, cloze probability, lexical association, concreteness, and semantic richness, while remaining insensitive to physical and syntactic manipulations that leave meaning intact (Kutas and Federmeier, 2011). For the present study, the N400 is reliably modulated in single-word and word-pair paradigms, with larger amplitudes for semantically unrelated than related targets, indexing the ease with which a word's meaning is integrated with concurrently activated semantic information: in the present design, the network of meanings associated with a stem's morphological family, rather than sentence- or discourse-level content.

Although both components are negative-going deflections occurring in adjacent time windows, they are dissociable by topography—the N250 has a more frontal distribution, the N400 a posterior one (Holcomb and Grainger, 2006)—and, more decisively, by a double dissociation across priming types. Lexical status selectively modulates the N400 in that priming effects are restricted to real words with semantic representations and do not extend to pseudowords (Kiyonaga et al., 2007), whereas the N250 is equally modulated by words and pseudowords alike. The reverse pattern holds for semantic relatedness; while associative priming reliably modulates the N400, it produces no N250 effect (Grainger and Holcomb, 2009). This double dissociation—pseudoword priming engaging the N250 but not the N400, semantic

priming engaging the N400 but not the N250—confirms that the two components index qualitatively distinct processing stages, and rules out the interpretation of the N250 as merely an early onset of the N400.

1.4 Aims and Predictions

The present study has two complementary aims. The first is to establish whether base frequency and morphological family size exert their effects at distinct temporal stages of visual word recognition, using ERP to track processing in real time. The second, and primary, aim builds on this: to examine whether individual differences in orthographic and semantic processing, captured by two continuous dimensions, Orthographic Sensitivity (OS) and Language Proficiency (LP), derived from a principal components analysis of spelling ability, vocabulary knowledge, and print exposure, modulate these effects selectively, at the processing stages where each variable is predicted to operate.

Although OS and LP are orthogonal dimensions rather than poles of a single continuum, they nonetheless differ in their primary loading: OS captures relatively greater precision of sublexical orthographic representation, while LP captures relatively greater breadth of lexical-semantic knowledge. The core prediction is therefore a double dissociation; Orthographic Sensitivity should modulate base frequency effects at the level of early form-based processing, as indexed by the N250, while Language Proficiency should modulate family size effects at the level of semantic integration, as indexed by the N400. This prediction follows directly from Andrews and Lo's (2013) finding that the balance between orthographic and semantic processing is a genuine and measurable axis of individual variation, combined with the broadly shared theoretical assumption that base frequency reflects form-level access and family size reflects the richness of semantic representation. If this double dissociation is observed, it would constitute direct electrophysiological evidence that the distinction between form-based and meaning-based morphological processing is not merely a property of competing computational models but a real axis of variation in the reading system. If, instead, both variables are modulated by the same individual difference dimension at the same processing stage, this would suggest that the two effects are less dissociable than current multi-stage accounts propose.

The first analysis examines these predictions in real word recognition. Because real words were not matched across morphological variables, reflecting the naturalistic distributional properties of morphologically complex words rather than an orthogonally controlled factorial design, base frequency, family size, and morphological complexity are treated as continuous predictors in a regression framework for reaction times. For ERP data, items were median-split into high and low groups separately for base frequency and family size to yield stable waveforms for comparison. The two measures therefore carry somewhat different inferential weight; the RT regression speaks to the independent continuous contributions of each variable, while the ERP analyses speak to the direction and timing of effects at the extremes of each variable's distribution.

The second analysis examines whether these individual difference modulations generalise to novel morphological structure, using morphologically complex nonwords. Morphologically structured nonwords (e.g., *gasful*: real stem + real affix) were compared against matched controls (e.g., *gasfil*: real stem + pseudoaffix), holding stem identity constant while manipulating suffix legitimacy. Because these items have no stored whole-word representations, they place maximal pressure on the system's generalisation mechanism and allow stem-level variables to be examined independently of whole-word familiarity. The key prediction is that Orthographic Sensitivity should modulate early N250 responses to the suffix contrast. For nonwords specifically, no stored whole-word entry exists, so early processing must rely on readers' sublexical orthographic knowledge. Readers with more precise representations of real suffix forms should

show greater N250 sensitivity to the distinction between real and pseudo-suffixes, consistent with affix-led parsing accounts (Taft and Forster, 1975; Rastle and Davis, 2008). Language Proficiency, by contrast, should predict later N400 modulation; readers with broader and more richly specified lexical-semantic knowledge should show stronger N400 sensitivity to whether a nonword's stem belongs to a large or productive morphological family, since it is this family membership that determines the richness of the semantic activation the form can support. However, the predicted dissociation between OS at the N250 and LP at the N400 may not be fully clean for nonwords. Beyersmann et al. (2016) found that readers higher in overall reading proficiency showed embedded stem priming effects independent of affix status, suggesting that stem activation in skilled readers is not contingent on affix recognition and that stem- and affix-based parsing mechanisms may operate concurrently. Because Beyersmann et al.'s proficiency measure was not decomposed into orthographic and lexical-semantic components, it is unclear whether this effect reflects Orthographic Sensitivity, Language Proficiency, or both. The present study is therefore in a position to address this question more precisely: if stem-based parsing is specifically associated with Language Proficiency rather than Orthographic Sensitivity, this would suggest that the stem-based mechanism is driven by depth of lexical-semantic knowledge rather than sublexical orthographic sensitivity, consistent with the theoretical distinction between the two dimensions developed above. This leads to the prediction that LP may contribute to N250 modulation for nonwords alongside OS, potentially through a stem-based parsing mechanism that is distinct from the affix-led account. This is an interpretation that the complex versus simple nonword contrast is well-suited to evaluate, since it holds stem identity constant while manipulating suffix legitimacy.

2 METHODS

2.1 Materials

The experimental stimulus set included 200 nonwords, constructed to manipulate morphological structure while controlling surface form. In the *complex nonword* condition, we combined existing English base words (e.g., *gas*) with existing derivational suffixes (e.g., *gasful*), to yield 100 morphologically plausible complex nonwords. Each combination was syntactically legal and reflected common English derivational patterns. A total of 16 suffixes were used, each attached to four different stems.

In the *simple nonword* condition, we combined the same base words as in the complex non-word condition with non-suffix endings that were orthographically similar to the real suffixes used in the complex condition but did not constitute valid morphemes, to yield 100 orthographically plausible simple non-words. These pseudoaffix endings were created by changing the central letter of each suffix (e.g., *gasful*–*gasfil*), preserving length and orthographic neighborhood characteristics while eliminating morphological structure. Thus each complex non-word had an orthographically matched simple counterpart.

Because the same base appeared in both the simple and complex conditions, the experimental nonwords were distributed across two lists such that no participant encountered the same base more than once. In addition to the experimental nonwords, the stimulus set included 100 monomorphemic fillers (50 real words and 50 nonwords) to balance lexical status and reduce predictability. The experimental stimuli were drawn from Sawi (2016)

Estimates of cumulative base (root) frequency, surface frequency, and morphological family size were obtained from the CELEX lexical database. Morphological family size was calculated by identifying all morphologically related forms sharing the same base (e.g., *calculate*, *calculable*, *calculation*, *calculator*). Following prior work (e.g., de Jong et al., 2000, 2002), both compounds (e.g., *WATCHTOWER*) and

hyphenated compounds (e.g., *CHECK-IN*) were included, as they contribute to morphological connectivity within the lexicon. Base frequency was computed by summing the lemma frequencies of all confirmed family members.

For reaction time analyses, all lexical and individual-difference variables were treated as continuous predictors to preserve information and maximize statistical power. In contrast, ERP analyses were conducted on condition-averaged waveforms to improve signal-to-noise ratio; as a result, item-level predictors such as base frequency and family size were operationalized as categorical condition factors rather than continuous trial-level covariates. This distinction reflects standard practice in ERP research and aligns the statistical treatment of predictors with the structure of the underlying data.

2.2 Individual Differences and Grouping Variables

To quantify individual differences in linguistic experience and orthographic knowledge, participants completed three standardized measures—the Nelson–Denny Vocabulary Test (Brown et al., 1993), a spelling task adapted from Sawi (2016), and the Author Recognition Test (ART; Stanovich and West 1989). Scores on these measures were moderately correlated ($r_s = .29-.51$, all $p < .02$), indicating partially overlapping but dissociable components of lexical experience.

To capture the shared and distinct variance among these measures, we conducted a principal components analysis (PCA) on standardized (z-scored) vocabulary, spelling, and ART scores. PCA was selected to derive orthogonal dimensions of individual differences without imposing a priori weighting or categorical group boundaries. Two components had eigenvalues greater than 1, jointly accounting for 83.5% of the total variance (58.0% for Dimension 1 and 25.5% for Dimension 2).

Component loadings (Table 1) indicated that Dimension 1 loaded most strongly on vocabulary and print exposure (ART), with a secondary contribution from spelling accuracy, and was interpreted as indexing *Language Proficiency*. Dimension 2 loaded most strongly on spelling accuracy, with weaker and oppositely signed contributions from vocabulary and ART, and was interpreted as indexing *Orthographic Sensitivity*:

- *Dimension 1 (Language Proficiency)*: vocabulary (.82), ART (.81), spelling (.65)
- *Dimension 2 (Orthographic Sensitivity)*: spelling (.76), vocabulary (−.29), ART (−.32)

The two components were statistically independent ($r \approx 0$), supporting their interpretation as orthogonal dimensions of reading-related skill. These continuous component scores were used as predictors in all behavioral and ERP analyses.

Table 1. PCA loadings and variance explained for the three lexical-experience measures.

Measure	Dimension 1 (Language Proficiency)	Dimension 2 (Orthographic Sensitivity)
Vocabulary (z_vcb)	0.82	−0.29
Spelling (z_spl)	0.65	0.76
Author Recognition Test (z_art)	0.81	−0.32
<i>Eigenvalue</i>	1.74	0.76
<i>Variance explained (%)</i>	58.0	25.5

2.3 Statistical Analyses

The analyses are organized around the study's primary theoretical aim—determining whether Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency dissociably modulate the timing and nature of morphological processing. We predicted that Orthographic Sensitivity would selectively modulate early, form-based processing indexed by the N250, while Language Proficiency would selectively modulate later semantic integration indexed by the N400. The behavioral and ERP results are reported separately for words and nonwords in each section, followed by a summary that evaluates these predictions against the obtained pattern.

2.3.1 Behavioral Data (Reaction Times)

Reaction time (RT) analyses were conducted on correct responses only. RTs were log-transformed to reduce positive skew and to better meet model assumptions of normality and homoscedasticity. Separate analyses were conducted for word and nonword trials: for words, base frequency and family size were the primary morphological predictors; for nonwords, morphological complexity (real vs. pseudo-suffix) was the key manipulation, with base frequency and family size included as covariates (see Aims and Predictions).

RTs were analyzed using linear mixed-effects models fit with the `lme4` package (Bates et al., 2015) in R (R Core Team, 2026). All models included random intercepts for participants and items, and random slopes for within-participant predictors where supported by the data. Continuous lexical predictors (log base frequency and log family size) were mean-centered and scaled prior to analysis. Individual-difference measures—Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency—were entered as continuous predictors corresponding to standardized PCA scores.

For word trials, models tested the effects of base frequency, family size, Orthographic Sensitivity, and Language Proficiency, as well as interactions between Orthographic Sensitivity and lexical familiarity measures. For nonword trials, models additionally included morphological complexity (simple vs. complex) as a categorical predictor and tested whether complexity effects were modulated by individual differences. Treatment (reference) coding was used for categorical predictors in RT analyses. Model significance was assessed using Type III tests with Satterthwaite-approximated degrees of freedom. Fixed-effect estimates are reported alongside model-based estimated marginal means where relevant. Means are reported in milliseconds following back-transformation from the log scale used in analysis.

2.3.2 ERP Data

For word stimuli, ERP trials were averaged separately according to median splits on base frequency and morphological family size, enabling separate analyses of each variable at the N250 and N400. For nonword stimuli, trials were averaged according to a median split on morphological family size.

The choice of primary item-level variable differed across stimulus types for theoretically motivated reasons. For word stimuli, base frequency was treated as the primary morphological variable of interest in the ERP analyses, because it indexes the strength of the stored lexical representation — how well-entrenched the stem form is in the reader's mental lexicon as a function of accumulated encounter frequency. This makes it the most theoretically relevant item-level variable for examining individual differences in how stored lexical representations are accessed and processed at each ERP stage. For nonword stimuli, morphological family size was treated as the primary item-level variable, because nonwords have no stored whole-word representations and processing must rely on stem-level morphological properties. Family size indexes the richness of the stem's morphological neighbourhood — how many distinct derived words share

the stem and reinforce its semantic core — and is therefore the most theoretically relevant variable for examining how morphological family information is recruited when processing a novel form in the absence of whole-word familiarity. This asymmetry between stimulus types reflects the distinct theoretical roles of the word and nonword analyses: words examine the time course of stored lexical representation access, while nonwords examine morphological generalisation to novel forms.

Within the nonword analyses, family size's statistical role further differed across the two time windows: at the N400 it was a primary predictor of theoretical interest, entering into three-way interactions with Morphological Complexity and each individual difference dimension; at the N250 it was retained as a covariate to reduce item-level variance rather than as a predictor of theoretical interest in its own right. Because base frequency and family size are properties of the stem shared across both members of each complexity pair (e.g., *gasful* and *gasfil* share the same stem), neither variable could confound the complexity manipulation. Family size was preferred over base frequency as the N250 covariate on empirical grounds: preliminary model comparisons indicated that family size accounted for substantially more item-level variance in the nonword N250 data (residual variance: 4.07 vs. 27.47). The pattern of interactions reported below was equivalent in direction when base frequency was used as the covariate instead.

ERP analyses were conducted on mean amplitudes computed from condition-averaged waveforms. Separate datasets were constructed for words and nonwords, and analyses were conducted independently for the N250 and N400 time windows. Because ERP amplitudes were derived from condition-level averages rather than trial-level data, morphological predictors in ERP analyses were treated as categorical condition factors rather than continuous covariates.

ERP amplitudes were analysed using linear mixed-effects models. For word stimuli, separate models were fit for base frequency and family size, each entered as the primary morphological predictor along with Orthographic Sensitivity, Language Proficiency, and their interaction with the morphological predictor. The non-interacting individual difference dimension was included as a covariate in each model: Language Proficiency was a covariate in the N250 models, and Orthographic Sensitivity was a covariate in the N400 models. For nonword stimuli, model structure differed across time windows to reflect the distinct role of family size at each stage. At the N250, models included fixed effects of Morphological Complexity, Orthographic Sensitivity, Language Proficiency, interactions between Complexity and each individual difference dimension, and Morphological Family Size as a covariate. At the N400, a single symmetric model was fit including fixed effects of Morphological Complexity, Morphological Family Size, Language Proficiency, Orthographic Sensitivity, and all two- and three-way interactions among Complexity, Family Size, and each individual difference dimension separately. This symmetric structure permitted direct comparison of the roles of LP and OS in modulating the joint influence of morphological complexity and family size on N400 amplitude, providing a formal test of the predicted dissociation between the two dimensions rather than assuming it in the model specification. All models included random intercepts for participants and for electrode site nested within participant, allowing baseline amplitude differences across electrodes to be modelled while preserving the spatial structure of the data.

Categorical predictors in ERP analyses were effect-coded (sum-to-zero coding), such that model intercepts represent grand mean amplitudes and main effects reflect average effects across conditions. Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency were entered as continuous, mean-centred predictors. Time window was not included as a factor in the models; instead, separate models were fit for the N250 and N400 to preserve component-specific interpretation.

387 Statistical significance of fixed effects was assessed using Type III *F*-tests with Satterthwaite-
 388 approximated degrees of freedom as implemented in the `lmerTest` package (Bates et al., 2015).
 389 Where higher-order interactions involving individual-difference measures were significant, follow-up
 390 analyses were conducted using estimated marginal means (`emmeans`). Interactions involving Orthographic
 391 Sensitivity and Language Proficiency were probed by estimating contrasts across the observed range of
 392 each dimension in the sample, allowing direct tests of whether morphological effects differed as a function
 393 of reader skill and characterising the full extent of any reversals across the individual difference continua.

394 2.3.3 Model Estimation and Inference

395 All mixed-effects models were fit using restricted maximum likelihood estimation. To ensure stable
 396 convergence, models were estimated using the BOBYQA optimizer. Continuous predictors were centered
 397 to facilitate interpretation of interaction terms and model intercepts. For predictors with one degree of
 398 freedom, *F*-tests from the analysis-of-variance tables are mathematically equivalent to squared *t*-tests from
 399 model summaries; all inferential conclusions are therefore invariant to the choice of reporting format.
 400 Across all analyses, inferential emphasis was placed on theoretically motivated interactions rather than
 401 exhaustive post hoc comparisons. Follow-up contrasts were conducted only where warranted by significant
 402 interactions and were limited to tests directly addressing the study's hypotheses. Estimated marginal
 403 means and confidence intervals were obtained using the `emmeans` package (Lenth and Piaskowski, 2026);
 404 confidence intervals are based on asymptotic approximation, which is appropriate given the sample size.

3 RESULTS

405 The analyses are organised around two complementary sources of evidence bearing on the study's primary
 406 theoretical aim — determining whether Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency dissociably
 407 modulate the timing and nature of morphological processing. Reaction time models included individual
 408 difference measures as main effects only, reflecting the theoretical framing of behavioural responses as
 409 indices of overall processing efficiency. Interactions between morphological variables and individual
 410 differences were examined in the ERP models, where the temporal resolution of the N250 and N400
 411 allows these effects to be attributed to specific processing stages. Results are reported separately for words
 412 and nonwords. For each stimulus type, behavioural results are presented first, followed by ERP results
 413 organised by component, N250 then N400, reflecting the temporal sequence of morphological processing.
 414 This organisation reflects the distinct theoretical roles of the two stimulus types — the word analyses
 415 examine the time course of base frequency and family size effects in stored lexical representations, while
 416 the nonword analyses examine whether morphological sensitivity generalises to novel forms and whether
 417 individual differences modulate that generalisation. Within each section, the pattern of effects is evaluated
 418 against the predictions derived from morpho-orthographic decomposition accounts and the Lexical Quality
 419 Hypothesis, with particular attention to whether Orthographic Sensitivity selectively modulates early
 420 form-based processing and Language Proficiency selectively modulates later semantic integration.

421 Table 2 summarises the fixed effects and interaction terms included in each model. For word stimuli,
 422 separate ERP models were run for base frequency and family size, with an asymmetric interaction structure
 423 in which Orthographic Sensitivity is the primary moderator at the N250, reflecting early form-based
 424 processing, and Language Proficiency is the primary moderator at the N400, reflecting later semantic
 425 integration; the non-interacting individual difference dimension was included as a covariate in each model.
 426 For nonword stimuli, the N250 model included interactions between morphological complexity and both
 427 individual difference dimensions, with family size included as a covariate. The nonword N400 model used

a symmetric structure testing both OS and LP within the same analysis, permitting direct comparison of the two dimensions and providing a formal test of the predicted dissociation. Reaction time models included individual difference measures as main effects only, reflecting the theoretical framing of behavioural responses as indices of overall processing efficiency rather than processing architecture.

Table 2. Summary of linear mixed-effects models. OS = Orthographic Sensitivity; LP = Language Proficiency; BF = Base Frequency; FS = Family Size; Cmplx = Morphological Complexity. All models fit by REML using the `bobyqa` optimizer. Degrees of freedom estimated using Satterthwaite's method. RE = random effects; Subj = participant; Elec = electrode site nested within participant. [†] = included as covariate only. [‡] = reported briefly in main text alongside the corresponding base frequency model; full model output in Supplementary Table S1. [§] = as [‡]; full model output in Supplementary Table S2.

Stimulus	Outcome Variable		Fixed effects	Interaction(s)	RE structure
Words	RT	BF + FS	BF, FS, OS, LP	None	Subj, Item
Words	N250	BF	BF, OS, LP [†]	BF × OS	Subj, Elec/Subj
Words	N250	FS [‡]	FS, OS, LP [†]	FS × OS	Subj, Elec/Subj
Words	N400	BF	BF, LP, OS [†]	BF × LP	Subj, Elec/Subj
Words	N400	FS [§]	FS, LP, OS [†]	FS × LP	Subj, Elec/Subj
Nonwords	RT	BF + FS	Cmplx, BF, FS, OS, LP	None	Subj (Cmplx slope), Item
Nonwords	N250	FS [†]	Cmplx, OS, LP, FS [†]	Cmplx × OS, Cmplx × LP	Subj, Elec/Subj
Nonwords	N400	FS	Cmplx, FS, LP, OS	Cmplx × FS × LP, Cmplx × FS × OS	Subj, Elec/Subj

The model structure reflected in Table 2 warrants brief explanation. For word stimuli, separate ERP models were run for base frequency and family size at each time window, reflecting the fact that these variables were operationalised as separate median-split factors in distinct datasets. At the N250, both the base frequency and family size models tested the interaction with Orthographic Sensitivity, consistent with the prediction that early form-based processing is selectively modulated by sublexical orthographic knowledge; Language Proficiency was included as a covariate in both models. The corresponding N400 models reversed this structure, testing interactions with Language Proficiency and including Orthographic Sensitivity as a covariate. This asymmetric structure for word stimuli reflects the theoretical predictions developed in the Aims and Predictions section: OS is predicted to modulate early form-based processing indexed by the N250, while LP is predicted to modulate later semantic integration indexed by the N400.

For nonword stimuli, base frequency was included as a covariate in the RT model but was not independently examined in the ERP analyses. At the N250, morphological family size was included as a covariate to reduce item-level variance rather than as a predictor of theoretical interest; the primary fixed effects were Morphological Complexity and its interactions with both individual difference dimensions, reflecting the prediction that early processing of novel forms is modulated by reader skill. At the N400, family size was elevated to a primary predictor, entering into three-way interactions with Morphological Complexity and each individual difference dimension simultaneously. Both OS and LP were included as interacting variables within the same symmetric model, permitting direct comparison of their roles in modulating the joint influence of morphological complexity and family size on N400 amplitude, and providing a formal test of the predicted dissociation between the two dimensions. This distinction in the

role of family size across the two nonword ERP models reflects the theoretical rationale developed in the Aims and Predictions section: family size indexes the richness of the morphological neighbourhood and is predicted to modulate semantic integration specifically at the N400, where the precision of lexical-semantic representations — indexed by LP — determines whether that richness facilitates or burdens processing. The symmetric model structure ensures that this prediction is tested against the alternative that OS, rather than LP, drives the family size modulation, rather than assuming the dissociation in the model specification itself.

3.1 Words

Words RT

Reaction times (RTs) for correct lexical decisions to word stimuli were analyzed using a linear mixed-effects model with fixed effects of Base Frequency, Family Size, Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), and Language Proficiency (LP). The model included random intercepts for participants and items. The analysis revealed robust main effects of item-level lexical familiarity. As base frequency increased, recognition times decreased, $\beta = -0.017$, $SE = 0.005$, $t(100.97) = -3.66$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .12$. Similarly, words from larger morphological families elicited faster responses than those from smaller families, $\beta = -0.013$, $SE = 0.005$, $t(93.59) = -2.64$, $p = .010$, $\eta_p^2 = .07$. Orthographic Sensitivity showed a marginal trend toward faster overall response times, $\beta = -0.035$, $SE = 0.019$, $t(63.84) = -1.85$, $p = .069$, $\eta_p^2 = .05$. Language Proficiency did not exert a reliable main effect on RTs, $\beta = 0.012$, $SE = 0.012$, $t(63.97) = 0.94$, $p = .35$. The model explained 3.3% of the variance via fixed effects ($R_{\text{marginal}}^2 = .033$) and 41.7% overall ($R_{\text{conditional}}^2 = .417$). These findings indicate that word recognition speed is driven primarily by item-level lexical familiarity; Orthographic Sensitivity shows only a marginal and unstable influence on overall response efficiency and does not selectively modulate morphological effects on response times.

Words N250: Base Frequency

Mean N250 amplitudes for word stimuli were analyzed using a linear mixed-effects model with fixed effects of Base Frequency (high vs. low), Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), Language Proficiency (LP), and the interaction between Base Frequency and OS. The model included random intercepts for participants and for electrode site nested within participant. The analysis revealed a significant main effect of Base Frequency—words from higher-frequency bases elicited more negative N250 amplitudes than words from lower-frequency bases, $M_{\text{high}} = -1.63 \mu\text{V}$, 95% CI $[-2.56, -0.69]$, $M_{\text{low}} = -1.29 \mu\text{V}$, 95% CI $[-2.22, -0.36]$, $\beta = -0.318$, $SE = 0.100$, $t(1618) = -3.18$, $p = .002$, $\eta_p^2 = .006$. Neither Orthographic Sensitivity, $\beta = 0.534$, $SE = 0.520$, $t(57) = 1.03$, $p = .309$, nor Language Proficiency, $\beta = -0.536$, $SE = 0.378$, $t(57) = -1.42$, $p = .162$, yielded reliable main effects. Critically, the interaction between Base Frequency and Orthographic Sensitivity was significant, $\beta = -0.455$, $SE = 0.112$, $t(1618) = -4.06$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .010$, indicating that the magnitude of early base frequency effects is modulated by orthographic skill. The negative direction of the interaction indicates that readers higher in Orthographic Sensitivity showed an amplified N250 base frequency effect—a larger difference in early processing amplitude between high- and low-frequency stems—relative to readers lower in OS, consistent with the interpretation that more precise sublexical orthographic representations strengthen early morpheme-level activation signatures. The model explained 1.8% of variance via fixed effects ($R_{\text{marginal}}^2 = .018$) and 80.1% overall ($R_{\text{conditional}}^2 = .801$).

A parallel analysis conducted on family size showed a similar pattern: words from smaller morphological families elicited more negative N250 amplitudes than words from larger families, $\beta = 0.324$, $SE = 0.058$,

504 $t(1618) = 5.54, p < .001, \eta_p^2 = .02$, consistent with the form-meaning distinction developed in the
 505 Discussion, whereby richer family structure provides top-down semantic support that reduces early
 506 processing demands. The Family Size $\times$ OS interaction showed a marginal trend in the same direction as
 507 the base frequency interaction above, $\beta = -0.111, SE = 0.065, t(1618) = -1.70, p = .089$, but did not
 508 reach significance. Full model output for the family size analysis is reported in Supplementary Table S1.

499 **Words N400: Base Frequency**

500 Mean N400 amplitudes for word stimuli were analysed using a linear mixed-effects model with fixed
 501 effects of Base Frequency (high vs. low), Language Proficiency (LP), Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), and the
 502 interaction between Base Frequency and LP. The model included random intercepts for participants and for
 503 electrode site nested within participant. The analysis revealed a significant main effect of Base Frequency
 504 — averaged across LP levels, words from higher-frequency bases elicited more positive N400 amplitudes
 505 than words from lower-frequency bases, $M_{\text{high}} = 0.71 \mu\text{V}$, 95% CI $[-0.44, 1.86]$, $M_{\text{low}} = 0.52 \mu\text{V}$, 95%
 506 CI $[-0.63, 1.66]$, $\beta = 0.214, SE = 0.106, t(1618) = 2.01, p = .044, \eta_p^2 = .003$. A significant main effect
 507 of Orthographic Sensitivity was also observed, $\beta = 1.290, SE = 0.640, t(57) = 2.02, p = .049, \eta_p^2 = .07$,
 508 reflecting overall differences in N400 amplitude as a function of Orthographic Sensitivity, independently of
 509 morphological structure — a pattern consistent with the OS main effect observed in the family size model
 510 below. Although this effect was significant, the p -value was close to the conventional threshold ($p = .049$),
 511 and should be interpreted with appropriate caution. Language Proficiency did not yield a reliable main
 512 effect, $\beta = 0.047, SE = 0.465, t(57) = 0.10, p = .920$.

513 Critically, the interaction between Base Frequency and Language Proficiency was significant, $\beta = 0.344$,
 514 $SE = 0.087, t(1618) = 3.98, p < .001, \eta_p^2 = .010$. Follow-up contrasts examined the base frequency
 515 effect at LP values from -2 to $+2$ SD, spanning most of the observed LP range (-2.67 to $+3.11$). The
 516 direction of the base frequency effect reversed across the LP continuum. At LP = -2 SD, high base
 517 frequency words elicited more negative N400 amplitudes than low base frequency words ($\Delta = -0.470 \mu\text{V}$,
 518 $t(1618) = -2.38, p = .018$; EMM: High = $0.28 \mu\text{V}$, Low = $0.76 \mu\text{V}$). At LP = -1 SD the contrast was
 519 not significant ($\Delta = -0.130 \mu\text{V}, t(1618) = -0.97, p = .333$). At mean LP the direction had reversed,
 520 with high base frequency words now eliciting more positive N400 amplitudes than low base frequency
 521 words ($\Delta = 0.210 \mu\text{V}, t(1618) = 2.01, p = .044$; EMM: High = $0.72 \mu\text{V}$, Low = $0.51 \mu\text{V}$), and this
 522 pattern strengthened monotonically at LP = $+1$ SD ($\Delta = 0.560 \mu\text{V}, t(1618) = 3.99, p < .001$; EMM:
 523 High = $0.94 \mu\text{V}$, Low = $0.38 \mu\text{V}$) and LP = $+2$ SD ($\Delta = 0.900 \mu\text{V}, t(1618) = 4.37, p < .001$; EMM:
 524 High = $1.16 \mu\text{V}$, Low = $0.26 \mu\text{V}$). The participant LP scores ranged from -2.67 to $+3.11$, confirming
 525 that estimates at ± 2 SD are grounded in observed data rather than extrapolation. Together, these contrasts
 526 indicate that LP modulates the contribution of base frequency to N400 amplitude in a manner that crosses
 527 over across the LP continuum, with the nature of that modulation shifting from a pattern in which high base
 528 frequency words are harder to process semantically at low LP, to one in which they are easier to process
 529 at high LP. The model explained 2.6% of variance via fixed effects ($R_{\text{marginal}}^2 = .026$) and 82.5% overall
 530 ($R_{\text{conditional}}^2 = .825$).

531 A parallel analysis conducted on family size revealed a robust main effect, with words from smaller
 532 morphological families eliciting greater N400 amplitudes than words from larger families, $\beta = 0.452$,
 533 $SE = 0.064, t(1618) = 7.07, p < .001, \eta_p^2 = .03$, consistent with facilitated semantic integration for
 534 words supported by richer morphological families. A significant main effect of Orthographic Sensitivity
 535 was also observed in this model, $\beta = 0.677, SE = 0.318, t(57) = 2.13, p = .038, \eta_p^2 = .07$, mirroring
 536 the OS main effect reported above. Unlike base frequency, however, family size did not interact with

Language Proficiency, $\beta = -0.071$, $SE = 0.052$, $t(1618) = -1.37$, $p = .172$, suggesting that LP does not selectively modulate the semantic contribution of family size for familiar words, plausibly because stored whole-word representations reduce the need to recruit family-level semantic information during access. Full model output for the family size analysis is reported in Supplementary Table S2.

3.2 Nonwords

Nonwords RT

Reaction times (RTs) for correct lexical decisions to nonwords were analyzed using a linear mixed-effects model with fixed effects of Morphological Complexity (simple vs. complex), Base Frequency, Family Size, Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), and Language Proficiency (LP). The model included random intercepts for participants and items and by-participant random slopes for Complexity. The analysis revealed a strong main effect of Morphological Complexity—complex nonwords elicited slower responses than simple nonwords, $M_{\text{complex}} = 718.9$ ms, 95% CI [695.2, 743.4], $M_{\text{simple}} = 684.6$ ms, 95% CI [661.5, 708.5], $\beta = 0.049$, $SE = 0.005$, $t(62.68) = 9.13$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .57$. In addition, Base Frequency exerted a reliable inhibitory effect, $\beta = 0.015$, $SE = 0.005$, $t(98.21) = 3.05$, $p = .003$, $\eta_p^2 = .09$, such that nonwords derived from higher-frequency bases were responded to more slowly than those from lower-frequency bases. Family Size did not significantly influence response times, $\beta = -0.006$, $SE = 0.005$, $t(96.64) = -1.24$, $p = .22$. Orthographic Sensitivity showed a significant main effect, with higher-sensitivity participants responding more quickly overall, $\beta = -0.041$, $SE = 0.018$, $t(62.21) = -2.23$, $p = .030$, $\eta_p^2 = .07$. In contrast, there was no effect of Language Proficiency on nonword RTs, $\beta = 0.003$, $SE = 0.012$, $t(62.91) = 0.28$, $p = .78$. The model explained 5.0% of the variance via fixed effects ($R_{\text{marginal}}^2 = .050$) and 49.4% overall ($R_{\text{conditional}}^2 = .494$). Taken together, these results indicate that nonword decision latencies are strongly shaped by morphological complexity and item-level lexical familiarity, particularly base frequency, while individual differences primarily affect overall response efficiency, with more orthographically sensitive readers responding more quickly across conditions.

Nonwords N250

Mean N250 amplitudes for nonword stimuli were analysed using a linear mixed-effects model with fixed effects of Morphological Complexity, Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), Language Proficiency (LP), interactions between Complexity and each individual difference dimension, and Morphological Family Size as a covariate. The model included random intercepts for participants and for electrode site nested within participant.

The analysis revealed a significant main effect of Morphological Complexity, with complex nonwords eliciting more negative N250 amplitudes than simple nonwords overall ($M_{\text{complex}} = -0.759 \mu\text{V}$ [$-1.156, -0.363$], $M_{\text{simple}} = -0.526 \mu\text{V}$ [$-0.922, -0.130$]), $\beta = -0.233$, $SE = 0.050$, $t(4856) = -4.63$, $p < .001$. Morphological Family Size, included as a covariate, yielded a significant effect, $\beta = 0.182$, $SE = 0.050$, $t(4856) = 3.63$, $p < .001$, with large-family nonwords eliciting less negative amplitudes than small-family nonwords. Neither OS nor LP yielded reliable main effects, $\beta = 0.298$, $SE = 0.220$, $t(57) = 1.35$, $p = .181$; $\beta = -0.207$, $SE = 0.160$, $t(57) = -1.29$, $p = .202$, respectively.

The Complexity $\times$ OS interaction was significant, $\beta = 0.392$, $SE = 0.056$, $t(4856) = 6.98$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .010$. Follow-up contrasts examined the complexity effect across the observed OS range (-1.9 to $+1.9$ SD). The complexity effect was large and reliable at OS = -1.9 SD ($\Delta = 0.990 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 8.29$, $p < .001$) and at OS = -1 SD ($\Delta = 0.642 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 8.33$, $p < .001$), attenuated but still significant at mean OS ($\Delta = 0.250 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 4.98$, $p < .001$), and reversed in direction but only marginally significant

at OS = +1 SD ($\Delta = -0.142 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -1.93$, $p = .053$). At the upper extreme of the observed OS range (OS = +1.9 SD) the reversal was significant ($\Delta = -0.490 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -4.27$, $p < .001$). Examination of estimated marginal means indicated that this reversal was driven primarily by the trajectory of complex nonwords, which decreased in negativity across the OS range (EMM: $-1.720 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = -1.9 SD to $+0.160 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = $+1.9$ SD), while simple nonwords also decreased in negativity but more slowly (EMM: $-0.720 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = -1.9 SD to $-0.340 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = $+1.9$ SD).

The Complexity $\times$ LP interaction was also significant, $\beta = 0.358$, $SE = 0.041$, $t(4856) = 8.76$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .016$. Follow-up contrasts examined the complexity effect across the observed LP range (-2.5 to $+3.0$ SD). The complexity effect was large and reliable at LP = -2.5 SD ($\Delta = 1.110 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 9.92$, $p < .001$) and at LP = -1 SD ($\Delta = 0.574 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 9.05$, $p < .001$), attenuated but still significant at mean LP ($\Delta = 0.216 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 4.31$, $p < .001$), and significantly reversed at LP = $+1$ SD ($\Delta = -0.141 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -2.14$, $p = .032$) and strongly reversed at LP = $+3$ SD ($\Delta = -0.860 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -6.38$, $p < .001$). In contrast to the OS pattern, examination of estimated marginal means indicated that the LP reversal was driven entirely by the trajectory of simple nonwords, which became increasingly negative across the LP range (EMM: $+0.420 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = -2.5 SD to $-1.700 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = $+3.0$ SD), while complex nonwords remained essentially flat (EMM: $-0.690 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = -2.5 SD to $-0.840 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = $+3.0$ SD). Participant LP scores ranged from -2.67 to $+3.11$ and OS scores ranged from -1.98 to $+1.93$, confirming that all contrasts are grounded in observed data rather than extrapolation. Model fit indices were $R_{\text{marginal}}^2 = .025$ and $R_{\text{conditional}}^2 = .575$.

Nonwords N400

Mean N400 amplitudes for nonword stimuli were analysed using a single symmetric linear mixed-effects model including fixed effects of Morphological Complexity, Morphological Family Size, Language Proficiency (LP), Orthographic Sensitivity (OS), and all interactions among Complexity, Family Size, and each individual difference dimension separately. The model included random intercepts for participants and for electrode site nested within participant. This symmetric structure permitted direct comparison of the roles of LP and OS in modulating the joint influence of morphological complexity and family size at the N400, providing a formal test of the predicted dissociation between the two dimensions.

The analysis revealed a significant main effect of Morphological Complexity, with complex nonwords eliciting more negative N400 amplitudes than simple nonwords, $\beta = -0.469$, $SE = 0.061$, $t(4851) = -7.64$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .010$. Family Size did not yield a reliable main effect, $\beta = 0.085$, $SE = 0.061$, $t(4851) = 1.38$, $p = .168$. Neither LP, $\beta = 0.011$, $SE = 0.255$, $t(57) = 0.045$, $p = .964$, nor OS, $\beta = 0.381$, $SE = 0.350$, $t(57) = 1.09$, $p = .281$, yielded reliable main effects.

The Complexity $\times$ Family Size interaction was significant, $\beta = -0.446$, $SE = 0.123$, $t(4851) = -3.63$, $p < .001$, indicating that the N400 complexity effect was larger for nonwords from large morphological families than for those from small families, averaged across both individual difference dimensions. The Complexity $\times$ LP interaction was significant, $\beta = 0.254$, $SE = 0.050$, $t(4851) = 5.08$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .005$. Follow-up contrasts examined the complexity effect across the observed LP range (-2.5 to $+3.0$ SD), averaged over family size. The complexity effect was large and reliable at LP = -2.5 SD ($\Delta = 1.090 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 7.99$, $p < .001$) and at LP = -1 SD ($\Delta = 0.710 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 9.19$, $p < .001$), attenuated at mean LP ($\Delta = 0.460 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 7.48$, $p < .001$), and further reduced but still significant at LP = $+1$ SD ($\Delta = 0.210 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 2.54$, $p = .011$). At the upper limit of the observed LP range (LP = $+3$ SD) the complexity effect reversed in direction but did not reach significance ($\Delta = -0.300 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -1.84$, $p = .065$). The Family Size $\times$ LP interaction was also significant, $\beta = 0.122$, $SE = 0.050$, $t(4851) = 2.45$,

622 $p = .015$, indicating that the influence of family size on N400 amplitude varied as a function of LP; this
 623 interaction is qualified by the three-way interaction reported below. The Complexity $\times$ OS interaction was
 624 significant, $\beta = 0.240$, $SE = 0.069$, $t(4851) = 3.49$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .003$, indicating that the complexity
 625 effect also attenuated with increasing OS, though as reported below, OS did not selectively modulate
 626 the joint influence of complexity and family size. The Family Size $\times$ OS interaction was not significant,
 627 $\beta = 0.066$, $SE = 0.069$, $t(4851) = 0.955$, $p = .340$.

628 Critically, the three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction was significant, $\beta = 0.229$,
 629 $SE = 0.100$, $t(4851) = 2.29$, $p = .022$, $\eta_p^2 = .001$, while the corresponding Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$
 630 OS interaction was not significant, $\beta = 0.143$, $SE = 0.138$, $t(4851) = 1.04$, $p = .300$. This asymmetry
 631 — LP driving the three-way interaction while OS does not — constitutes the primary evidence for the
 632 predicted dissociation between the two individual difference dimensions at the N400.

633 Follow-up interaction contrasts for the significant LP three-way examined the Complexity $\times$ Family Size
 634 interaction separately across the observed LP range (-2.5 to $+3.0$ SD). At LP = -2.5 SD, the Complexity
 635 $\times$ Family Size interaction was large and highly reliable ($\Delta = -1.010 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -3.70$, $p < .001$) — the
 636 complexity effect was substantially larger for large-family nonwords ($\Delta = 1.600 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 8.26$, $p < .001$)
 637 than for small-family nonwords ($\Delta = 0.590 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 3.03$, $p = .002$), reflecting disproportionately strong
 638 semantic processing demands when both morphological complexity and family richness are high. At LP
 639 = -1 SD the interaction remained large and significant ($\Delta = -0.670 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -4.31$, $p < .001$), with
 640 complexity effects again larger for large-family ($\Delta = 1.050 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 9.55$, $p < .001$) than small-family
 641 nonwords ($\Delta = 0.380 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 3.45$, $p = .001$). At mean LP the interaction remained significant but
 642 attenuated ($\Delta = -0.440 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -3.58$, $p < .001$), with complexity effects larger for large-family
 643 ($\Delta = 0.680 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 7.82$, $p < .001$) than small-family nonwords ($\Delta = 0.240 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 2.76$, $p = .006$). At
 644 LP = $+1$ SD the interaction was no longer significant ($\Delta = -0.210 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -1.31$, $p = .192$), and at LP
 645 = $+3$ SD — the upper limit of the observed LP range — the interaction reversed in sign but did not reach
 646 significance ($\Delta = 0.250 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 0.76$, $p = .450$).

647 To characterise the nature of the LP modulation more precisely, follow-up contrasts examined the family
 648 size effect within complex nonwords specifically across the observed LP range. At LP = -2.5 SD, large-
 649 family complex nonwords elicited substantially more negative N400 amplitudes than small-family complex
 650 nonwords ($\Delta = 0.720 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 3.74$, $p < .001$). This difference decreased monotonically with increasing
 651 LP: at LP = -1 SD ($\Delta = 0.370 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 3.36$, $p = .001$), at mean LP ($\Delta = 0.130 \mu\text{V}$, $t = 1.53$, $p = .127$),
 652 and at LP = $+1$ SD the difference was negligible and non-significant ($\Delta = -0.100 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -0.91$,
 653 $p = .360$). At LP = $+3$ SD the pattern reversed significantly — small-family complex nonwords now
 654 elicited more negative N400 amplitudes than large-family complex nonwords ($\Delta = -0.580 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -2.49$,
 655 $p = .013$) — indicating that for highly proficient readers, morphological family richness facilitates rather
 656 than amplifies semantic integration demands for complex nonwords.

657 Although the Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ OS interaction was not significant, descriptive contrasts
 658 were conducted across the observed OS range (-1.9 to $+1.9$ SD) to characterise the nature of this null
 659 result and to directly compare the OS pattern with the LP pattern reported above. The Complexity $\times$
 660 Family Size interaction was significant at low OS (OS = -1.9 SD: $\Delta = -0.730 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -2.48$, $p = .013$;
 661 OS = -1 SD: $\Delta = -0.600 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -3.18$, $p = .001$) and at mean OS ($\Delta = -0.460 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -3.72$,
 662 $p < .001$), reflecting a pattern qualitatively similar to that seen at low LP. However, unlike the LP pattern,
 663 the interaction attenuated monotonically without reversing as OS increased: at OS = $+1$ SD the interaction
 664 was marginal ($\Delta = -0.310 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -1.75$, $p = .081$), and at the upper extreme of the observed OS
 665 range (OS = $+1.9$ SD) it was absent ($\Delta = -0.190 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -0.66$, $p = .512$). Crucially, the family size

effect within complex nonwords showed no significant reversal at any level of OS — at OS = +1.9 SD the contrast was negligible and non-significant ($\Delta = -0.110 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -0.55$, $p = .581$). This pattern of attenuation without reversal for OS, in contrast to the significant reversal at high LP, constitutes the clearest expression of the dissociation between the two dimensions at the N400. Participant LP scores ranged from -2.67 to $+3.11$ and OS scores ranged from -1.98 to $+1.93$, confirming that all contrasts are grounded in observed data rather than extrapolation. Model fit indices were $R^2_{\text{marginal}} = .013$ and $R^2_{\text{conditional}} = .667$.

4 DISCUSSION

The present study examined whether individual differences in Orthographic Sensitivity (OS) and Language Proficiency (LP) dissociably modulate morphological processing at distinct temporal stages, as indexed by the N250 and N400 components of the ERP. Three findings structure the discussion that follows. First, individual differences were largely absent from behavioural response times, with the exception of an OS advantage for nonword lexical decisions, indicating that the two dimensions differ in their contribution to general lexical decision efficiency but that neither selectively shapes the structure of morphological effects at the behavioural level. Second, at the N250, both OS and LP modulated the complexity effect for nonword stimuli through qualitatively distinct mechanisms that are developed in detail below, and OS selectively modulated the base frequency effect for word stimuli, providing partial support for the predicted role of orthographic skill in early morpho-orthographic parsing. Third, at the N400, a model testing both OS and LP within the same analysis revealed that LP selectively drove the three-way interaction between morphological complexity and family size for nonword stimuli, while the corresponding OS interaction was not significant — constituting the clearest evidence for the predicted dissociation between the two dimensions. LP also modulated base frequency effects for word stimuli in a crossover interaction consistent with LP determining how form-level frequency information is weighted during semantic access. Together these findings support a partial dissociation between OS and LP in morphological processing, with a mechanistically rich picture at the N250 and the clearest dissociation emerging at the N400.

4.1 Early Morpho-orthographic Processing: The N250

4.1.1 Word Stimuli

For word stimuli, readers higher in Orthographic Sensitivity showed larger N250 differences between high and low base frequency words — a pattern consistent with the prediction that early form-based processing is selectively shaped by the precision of sublexical orthographic representations. High base frequency words elicited more negative N250 amplitudes than low base frequency words, and this difference increased with OS, such that readers higher in Orthographic Sensitivity showed larger N250 amplitudes for high frequency bases. Morphological family size also modulated the N250 as a main effect, with large-family words eliciting less negative amplitudes than small-family words. There was a marginal trend toward a Family Size $\times$ OS interaction, $\beta = -0.111$, $SE = 0.065$, $t(1618) = -1.70$, $p = .089$, suggesting that as with base frequency, OS may modulate the sensitivity of early form-based processing to morphological family structure, though this effect did not reach significance.

The opposite directions of the base frequency and family size effects at the N250 are theoretically informative and can be accounted for by a distinction between form-level entrenchment and semantic reinforcement of morphological structure. Base frequency reflects how often an orthographic form has been encountered as the same lexical entry, across inflectional variants that share a stable meaning but do not create new form-meaning pairings at the lexical level. Family size, by contrast, reflects how many distinct

derived words embed the base, each constituting a separate lexical entry that pairs the base form with a related but distinct meaning. Repeated encounter of the same form across multiple such meaning-bearing contexts is argued to build richer, more precise semantic representations (Bolger et al., 2008; Li et al., 2026) — the semantic core of the base becomes more robustly specified as it is reinforced across independent form-meaning pairings. Under this account, it is the quality of the lexical representation associated with large family size — the precision and richness of the semantic core built through accumulated contextual variation — that enables stronger top-down semantic feedback to the form level, facilitating orthographic identification and reducing N250 amplitude. Base frequency does not carry this semantic reinforcement: repeated encounters with a high-frequency base accumulate orthographic familiarity without necessarily building new form-meaning pairings, and its effect at the N250 therefore reflects engagement of morpho-orthographic parsing that is not necessarily supplemented by feedback from a richly specified semantic representation.

The modulation of this base frequency effect by OS is consistent with the theoretical profile of this dimension. OS indexes sensitivity to sublexical orthographic structure, and readers higher in OS are more sensitive to the statistical and structural properties of sub-word units, including stem forms. For these readers, a high-frequency base strongly recruits morpho-orthographic parsing activity, producing greater N250 amplitude. The absence of a corresponding modulation by LP is consistent with the prediction that early form-based processing is specifically tied to orthographic skill rather than lexical-semantic knowledge, and supports the theoretical distinction between the two individual difference dimensions at this processing stage. As discussed below, however, the nonword data reveal a more complex picture at the N250, with LP also modulating early morphological parsing through a mechanistically distinct route.

High base frequency words elicited more negative N250 amplitudes than low base frequency words, and this difference increased with OS, such that readers higher in Orthographic Sensitivity showed larger N250 amplitudes for high frequency bases.

4.1.2 Nonword Stimuli

For nonword stimuli, both OS and LP modulated the N250 complexity effect, but through qualitatively distinct mechanisms that reflect the different processing profiles of the two dimensions. This constitutes a partial qualification of the predicted OS-specific modulation at the N250, but the nature of the qualification is itself theoretically informative: rather than reflecting a single shared mechanism operating at different strengths, the two dimensions produce reversals of the complexity effect through entirely distinct trajectories.

For readers lower in OS, complex nonwords elicited substantially more negative N250 amplitudes than simple nonwords, reflecting a large early processing cost associated with the presence of a real suffix. As OS increased, this complexity cost attenuated monotonically, reversing significantly at the upper extreme of the observed OS range (OS = +1.9 SD: $\Delta = -0.490 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -4.27$, $p < .001$), though not at OS = +1 SD ($\Delta = -0.142 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -1.93$, $p = .053$). Examination of estimated marginal means indicated that this reversal was driven primarily by the trajectory of complex nonwords, which decreased in negativity across the OS range (EMM: $-1.720 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = -1.9 SD to $+0.160 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = +1.9 SD), while simple nonwords also decreased in negativity but more slowly (EMM: $-0.720 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = -1.9 SD to $-0.340 \mu\text{V}$ at OS = +1.9 SD). We propose that this pattern reflects affix-led parsing (Taft and Forster, 1975; Rastle and Davis, 2008), in which the presence of a real suffix triggers morpho-orthographic parsing activity across all readers, but the efficiency with which that parsing proceeds varies with OS. For readers lower in OS, the parse is triggered by the real suffix but cannot be resolved fluently, producing a processing cost for

complex nonwords relative to simple ones. As OS increases, parsing becomes more efficient, reducing and eventually reversing the complexity cost. At very high OS, the parse is sufficiently efficient that complex nonwords become easier to process than simple ones, which lack a real suffix and therefore do not benefit from affix-based parsing in the same way. The reversal is therefore a consequence of the complex nonword trajectory outpacing the simple nonword trajectory as OS increases — not of a rising processing cost for simple nonwords.

The LP pattern was qualitatively different, and the contrast with the OS pattern constitutes a dissociation of mechanism within the nonword N250 data. As with OS, the complexity effect reversed at high LP — significantly so at LP = +1 SD ($\Delta = -0.141 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -2.14$, $p = .032$) and more strongly at LP = +3 SD ($\Delta = -0.860 \mu\text{V}$, $t = -6.38$, $p < .001$). However, examination of estimated marginal means indicated that the mechanism was entirely distinct from that underlying the OS reversal. Complex nonwords were essentially flat across the LP range (EMM: $-0.690 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = -2.5 SD to $-0.820 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = $+3.0$ SD), indicating that LP did not modulate the processing of complex nonwords. Instead, the reversal was driven entirely by simple nonwords becoming increasingly negative as LP increased, from $+0.420 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = -2.5 SD to $-1.700 \mu\text{V}$ at LP = $+3.0$ SD. We propose that this pattern reflects stem-led parsing: readers higher in LP have richer and more precise representations of stems as free morphemes with discrete lexical entries, and recognition of the stem in a nonword triggers an attempt to assign morphological structure to the whole string regardless of what follows. This proposal is consistent with Beyersmann et al. (2016), who found that high proficiency readers showed embedded stem priming effects independent of whether the stem was followed by a real affix or a non-affixal ending — a pattern suggesting that stem activation in skilled readers is not contingent on affix recognition, in contrast to the standard affix-stripping account (Taft and Forster, 1975; Rastle and Davis, 2008). For complex nonwords, the stem-led parse succeeds — a real stem is followed by a real suffix, yielding a valid morphological analysis — and successful parsing produces neither a cost nor a benefit at the N250, keeping amplitude stable across LP levels. For simple nonwords, the parse fails — the pseudoaffix cannot be integrated into a valid morphological structure — and this failed parse produces a processing cost that grows with LP, driving the simple nonword trajectory increasingly negative.

The contrast between the two reversal mechanisms is theoretically precise. The OS reversal is driven by the complex nonword trajectory: the real suffix triggers morpho-orthographic parsing in all readers, but higher OS readers resolve that parse more efficiently, driving complex nonwords to decrease in negativity faster than simple nonwords and eventually producing a reversal. Simple nonwords are not specifically affected by affix-based parsing efficiency because they do not contain a real suffix. The LP reversal is driven by the simple nonword trajectory: stem recognition triggers an attempt to assign morphological structure to the whole string in higher LP readers, and this attempt succeeds for complex nonwords — keeping their amplitude stable across LP levels — but fails for simple nonwords, producing a processing cost that grows with LP. This dissociation maps directly onto the theoretical profiles of the two dimensions: OS indexes the efficiency of sublexical orthographic processing, and its effect on early parsing is expressed specifically in the complex nonword condition, where the presence of a real affix drives differential parsing efficiency across OS levels; LP indexes the depth and precision of lexical-semantic knowledge, including knowledge of stems as free morphemes with discrete lexical entries, and its effect on early parsing is expressed specifically in the simple nonword condition, where stem recognition triggers a parse that cannot be resolved, producing a cost that grows with LP. The concurrent modulation of the N250 complexity effect by both OS and LP is consistent with Beyersmann et al. (2016)'s suggestion that affix-chunking and embedded stem activation mechanisms may operate concurrently during early morphological segmentation, with the present data extending this proposal by showing that these two mechanisms are dissociable across

individual difference dimensions: OS indexes the efficiency of affix-based parsing, while LP indexes the propensity for stem-based parsing independent of affix status.

This mechanistic distinction between OS and LP at the N250 for nonwords is further grounded by the word data reported above. For familiar words, OS modulated the base frequency effect at the N250 — a finding that reflects OS operating at the level of stem-form entrenchment in stored lexical representations. The specificity of the affix-led account for nonwords therefore does not imply that OS is exclusively sensitive to affixes in all contexts; rather, it suggests that when readers encounter a novel form for which no stored whole-word representation is available, OS-driven parsing activity is channelled specifically through affix recognition, because it is the affix that provides the primary morphological signal in that context. LP, by contrast, operates through stem recognition in both familiar and novel form processing, consistent with its profile as an index of the depth and precision of lexical-semantic representations in which stems are the primary meaning-bearing units.

4.2 Semantic Integration and the N400

The N400 findings provide the clearest support for the predicted dissociation between Orthographic Sensitivity and Language Proficiency. LP selectively modulated N400 amplitude in interaction with morphological variables across both word and nonword stimuli, consistent with the theoretical prediction that depth of lexical-semantic knowledge determines how morphological information is used during meaning access. OS modulated the overall N400 complexity effect for nonwords, reflecting a general reduction in semantic processing demands as orthographic processing becomes more efficient, but did not modulate the joint influence of morphological complexity and family size on N400 amplitude. To understand why the three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction — and not the corresponding OS interaction — constitutes the primary test of the predicted dissociation at the N400, it is necessary to be clear about what family size indexes and why LP is predicted to modulate its influence specifically at this later processing stage. When a reader encounters a morphologically complex form, the stem may activate semantic information associated with other words in its morphological family — derived words that share the stem and preserve its core meaning. The N400 reflects how easily that semantic activation is accessed and integrated. LP, as an index of the depth and precision of lexical-semantic representations, is predicted to determine whether the semantic richness of the morphological neighbourhood facilitates or burdens that integration process. OS, as an index of sublexical orthographic processing efficiency, is not predicted to selectively modulate this semantic process, and the data are consistent with that prediction. The asymmetry between LP and OS at the N400, established within a single model testing both dimensions simultaneously, provides the formal basis for the dissociation claim developed in the sections that follow.

4.2.1 Word Stimuli

For word stimuli, the direction of the base frequency effect at the N400 depended on LP: readers lower in LP showed greater N400 negativity for high than low frequency bases, while readers higher in LP showed the opposite pattern, with high frequency bases associated with less negative N400 amplitudes than low frequency bases. This pattern was not significant at LP = -1 SD but was significant at the lower and upper ends of the tested LP range, with the effect of base frequency in opposite directions at LP = -2 SD and LP = $+2$ SD.

This finding is consistent with the Lexical Quality Hypothesis (Perfetti, 2007), under which more proficient readers have more precise and fully specified lexical representations — involving tighter connections among orthographic, phonological, and semantic information — while less proficient readers

have less precise representations in which these connections are less fully specified. Under this account, LP modulates how base frequency contributes to N400 amplitude during semantic access: for readers lower in LP, higher base frequency is associated with greater N400 negativity, suggesting that base frequency influences how actively meaning retrieval is pursued; for readers higher in LP, higher base frequency is associated with less N400 negativity, suggesting that a more familiar orthographic form supports easier meaning retrieval. The direction of the base frequency effect therefore shifts across the LP continuum, with the pattern at low LP and the pattern at high LP reflecting different expressions of how form-level familiarity interacts with the precision of lexical representations during semantic access.

We note that the present data do not allow us to determine precisely why the direction of the base frequency effect shifts across LP levels. One possibility is that low and high LP readers differ in the degree to which they attempt meaning retrieval for words of varying familiarity — low LP readers mounting a more active retrieval attempt for familiar high frequency forms and a less thorough one for less familiar low frequency forms, while high LP readers retrieve meaning efficiently regardless of base frequency but do so more easily for more familiar forms. Another possibility is that the shift reflects a single continuous process in which LP modulates the weight given to base frequency during semantic access, with the direction of the effect changing as a mathematical consequence of that modulation across the LP range. The linear interaction term in the model is consistent with both accounts and cannot distinguish between them. Accuracy data would help to adjudicate: if low LP readers are less likely to correctly recognise low frequency words — treating them as nonwords more often — that would support the first account; if accuracy is comparable across base frequency levels for both LP groups, the second account would be more plausible.

4.2.2 Nonword Stimuli

The three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction illustrates the mechanistic dissociation between OS and LP at the N400, and is most readily understood by first considering why morphological family size might influence N400 amplitude at all. When a reader encounters a complex nonword like *gasful*, the stem *gas* activates other words in its morphological family — *gases*, *gassy*, *gaseous* — each of which shares the stem's core meaning. A stem with a large morphological family activates more semantic associates than one with a small family, creating a richer semantic network that must be evaluated against a form that has no stored lexical entry. Whether this richer activation constitutes a processing burden or a processing advantage depends on two factors simultaneously, as the three-way interaction reveals: whether the form signals a valid morphological structure — which determines whether the stem's morphological family is recruited during processing — and the precision of the reader's lexical-semantic representations, indexed by LP. For simple nonwords, the pseudoaffix does not signal a valid morphological structure. Without that morphological signal, the reader does not parse the string as a derived form and does not recruit the stem's morphological family as part of semantic processing. If family-level semantic activation is not recruited, its richness cannot influence processing, and LP — which determines how efficiently that activation is leveraged — has nothing to modulate. This is why the family size effect for simple nonwords is small and does not vary with LP. For complex nonwords, by contrast, the real suffix signals valid morphological structure, triggering recruitment of the stem's morphological family and making LP the critical determinant of whether that activation facilitates or burdens processing.

Figure ?? illustrates how LP modulates the family size effect specifically for complex nonwords. The figure plots N400 amplitude as a function of LP separately for large and small family nonwords, with simple and complex nonwords shown in separate panels. For simple nonwords, the family size lines are relatively flat and parallel across the LP range, consistent with the account above. For complex nonwords, the

880 picture is strikingly different: as LP increases, the amplitude for large-family complex nonwords decreases
881 substantially, while the amplitude for small-family complex nonwords remains relatively stable. At low
882 LP, large-family complex nonwords elicit considerably more negative N400 amplitudes than small-family
883 complex nonwords; at high LP, this difference reverses, with large-family complex nonwords eliciting
884 less negative amplitudes than small-family ones. It is this divergence of the large-family and small-family
885 trajectories specifically within complex nonwords, and the stability of those trajectories within simple
886 nonwords, that constitutes the three-way interaction.

887 This pattern is interpretable within the Lexical Quality Hypothesis (Perfetti, 2007), under which more
888 proficient readers have more precise and fully specified lexical representations, involving tighter connections
889 among orthographic, phonological, and semantic information. Under this framework, what differs across
890 LP levels is not the quantity of semantic activation generated by a large morphological family, but the
891 quality of the representations that are activated. High LP readers have precise, well-specified representations
892 of the stem's morphological relatives — each family member is a distinct, fully specified lexical entry with
893 a clear form-meaning relationship. When such a reader encounters a large-family complex nonword, the
894 activated semantic network is organised and coherent, and the reader can draw on this organised knowledge
895 to efficiently evaluate the novel form: they recognise the morphological structure, identify the stem and its
896 semantic core, and process the novel derived form against a well-specified representational background.
897 The result is less negative N400 amplitude for large-family complex nonwords at high LP — the richness of
898 the family facilitates rather than burdens processing. For readers lower in LP, the same network is activated
899 but the representations of family members are less precise and less fully specified. The reader cannot draw
900 on this activation as efficiently, and the additional semantic content generated by a large family creates
901 processing demands that are difficult to resolve against a novel form with no lexical entry. The result is
902 more negative N400 amplitude for large-family complex nonwords at low LP — the richness of the family
903 amplifies rather than reduces processing demands.

904 This account is also consistent with the distinction between base frequency and family size developed
905 in the context of the N250 findings. Family size reflects the richness of the semantic core built through
906 repeated encounter of a stable form with a stable meaning across multiple distinct form-meaning pairings
907 (Bolger et al., 2008; Li et al., 2026). It is precisely this semantic richness that makes family size a double-
908 edged variable at the N400: for readers whose representations are insufficiently precise to leverage it,
909 semantic richness amplifies processing demands; for readers whose representations are sufficiently precise,
910 it provides a processing advantage. Base frequency, which accumulates orthographic familiarity without
911 building new form-meaning pairings, does not carry this semantic richness, and its role at the N400 is
912 correspondingly different — modulating how form-level familiarity contributes to semantic access rather
913 than determining whether morphological family richness facilitates or burdens processing.

914 The OS pattern at the N400 stands in informative contrast to the LP pattern. OS reduced the overall
915 complexity effect at the N400 — higher OS readers showed a smaller difference in N400 amplitude between
916 complex and simple nonwords, consistent with more efficient orthographic processing reducing general
917 semantic processing demands. However, the three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ OS interaction was
918 not significant, indicating that OS did not modulate the family size effect for complex nonwords in the
919 way that LP did. Unlike the LP pattern, where the family size effect within complex nonwords reversed
920 significantly at high LP, the corresponding OS pattern showed only attenuation — the family size difference
921 for complex nonwords decreased as OS increased but did not reverse at any point across the observed OS
922 range. This dissociation — LP driving a reversal of the family size effect within complex nonwords while
923 OS produces only attenuation — is the clearest expression of the predicted dissociation between the two

dimensions at the N400. It suggests that while orthographic processing efficiency influences the general demands of semantic processing, it is the precision of lexical-semantic representations — indexed by LP — that specifically determines whether morphological family richness facilitates or burdens semantic integration of novel morphologically complex forms. Together, the word and nonword N400 findings converge on a coherent picture: LP indexes the precision of lexical-semantic representations, and it is this precision that determines how morphological information — whether the orthographic entrenchment of a familiar base or the semantic richness of a large morphological family — influences semantic access during morphological processing.

4.3 Behavioral and Neural Measures of Individual Differences in Morphological Processing

A consistent pattern across the present results is that individual differences in OS and LP were largely absent from behavioral response times but systematically present in the ERP components. This dissociation is not a null result but a theoretically meaningful finding: RT and ERPs index different aspects of lexical processing. Response times reflect the speed and outcome of the decision process — how quickly a reader reaches a response — while ERP components reflect the dynamics of processing as it unfolds in time, making visible the stages and mechanisms that contribute to that decision without being reducible to its speed.

For OS, the confirmatory RT models showed that higher OS predicted faster overall responding for nonword stimuli, consistent with orthographic processing efficiency contributing to the speed of lexical decisions for novel forms. However, OS did not selectively modulate how morphological structure influenced response times — the complexity effect and the base frequency effect were equivalent across OS levels in the confirmatory models. This pattern suggests that OS affects how efficiently orthographic information is processed without changing how morphological structure influences the decision process at the behavioral level. The ERP data tell a different story: OS modulated the base frequency effect at the N250 for words, and drove the affix-led reversal of the complexity effect at the N250 for nonwords. These effects are real and theoretically interpretable, but they do not propagate to the behavioral outcome in the form of differential morphological effects on RT.

For LP, the confirmatory RT models showed no reliable effect on overall response times for either words or nonwords. LP did not predict overall lexical decision speed, nor did it modulate morphological effects in the confirmatory models. Again, the ERP data reveal a different picture: LP drove the stem-led reversal of the complexity effect at the N250, and selectively modulated the three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size interaction at the N400. These are systematic and theoretically interpretable effects that are simply not visible in RT.

An exploratory model adding Complexity $\times$ OS and Complexity $\times$ LP interactions to the nonword RT model clarifies this picture further. The Complexity $\times$ OS interaction was not significant in the exploratory RT model ($\beta = -0.002$, $SE = 0.006$, $t(59) = -0.358$, $p = .721$), confirming that the OS modulation of morphological complexity visible at the N250 does not produce differential behavioral responses to complex and simple nonwords. The Complexity $\times$ LP interaction was significant ($\beta = 0.009$, $SE = 0.004$, $t(64) = 2.108$, $p = .039$), but in the opposite direction to the N250 pattern. Follow-up contrasts across the observed LP range showed that the complexity cost in RT — complex nonwords responded to more slowly than simple ones — grew monotonically with LP, from $\Delta = 0.026$ log ms at LP = -2.5 SD ($t = 2.17$, $p = .034$) to $\Delta = 0.074$ log ms at LP = $+3$ SD ($t = 5.70$, $p < .001$), with no reversal at any LP level. This contrasts sharply with the N250, where the complexity cost decreased and reversed with LP.

Rather than contradicting the neural account, this dissociation between the RT and N250 LP patterns is consistent with the stem-led parsing interpretation developed above. High LP readers engage in more thorough morphological analysis of complex nonwords before reaching a decision — recognising the stem, attempting to assign morphological structure, and evaluating the form against known morphological patterns. This analysis takes more time, producing a larger RT complexity cost. At the neural level, however, the parsing process itself is more efficient for high LP readers — the N250 reversal reflects that successful parsing of complex nonwords becomes facilitative while failed parsing of simple nonwords incurs a cost. The neural efficiency and the behavioral cost are therefore two sides of the same coin: high LP readers process morphological structure more efficiently at the parsing stage, but precisely because they engage more thoroughly with that structure, they take longer to reach a decision for complex nonwords that must ultimately be rejected.

This pattern has methodological implications for how individual differences in morphological processing are measured. Response times alone would suggest that OS and LP have limited and non-specific effects on morphological processing — OS predicts overall nonword decision speed, and LP predicts nothing. The ERP data reveal that both dimensions systematically modulate morphological processing at distinct temporal stages and through distinct mechanisms, in ways that are invisible to RT. This is consistent with the Lexical Quality Hypothesis (Perfetti, 2007), under which the precision of lexical representations affects the quality and architecture of processing rather than simply its speed. Individual differences in representational precision are therefore more readily detected by measures that track processing dynamics — such as ERP components — than by measures that index only the speed and outcome of the decision.

4.4 Theoretical Implications and Limitations

The present findings have several theoretical implications for accounts of morphological processing and individual differences in reading. We consider each in turn before addressing the limitations of the present study.

4.4.1 The Form-Meaning Distinction in Morphological Processing

A recurring theme across the N250 and N400 findings is the theoretical distinction between base frequency and morphological family size as indexing form-level entrenchment and semantic richness respectively. Base frequency reflects how often an orthographic form has been encountered as the same lexical entry, accumulating orthographic familiarity without necessarily building new form-meaning pairings. Family size reflects how many distinct derived words embed the base, each reinforcing the semantic core of the base form across multiple independent form-meaning pairings (Bolger et al., 2008; Li et al., 2026). This distinction accounts for the opposite directions of the two variables at the N250 — base frequency increasing N250 amplitude while family size reduces it — and for their different roles at the N400, where family size but not base frequency enters into the predicted three-way interaction with morphological complexity and LP.

The form-meaning distinction also provides a principled account of why OS and LP dissociate across time windows. OS indexes sensitivity to sublexical orthographic structure — the dimension of individual variation most directly relevant to form-level processing — and selectively modulates base frequency effects at the N250. LP indexes depth and breadth of lexical-semantic knowledge — the dimension most directly relevant to meaning-level processing — and selectively drives the three-way interaction involving family size at the N400. The dissociation between OS and LP therefore mirrors the dissociation between

the two morphological variables, with each individual difference dimension aligning with the variable that operates at its theoretically predicted processing stage.

4.4.2 Affix-Led and Stem-Led Parsing as Dissociable Mechanisms

The nonword N250 findings extend existing accounts of morphological decomposition by showing that affix-based and stem-based parsing mechanisms are dissociable across individual difference dimensions. Affix-stripping accounts (Taft and Forster, 1975; Rastle and Davis, 2008) propose that the affix is identified first and triggers decomposition, after which the stem is looked up in the lexicon. The OS pattern at the N250 is consistent with this account: OS modulates the efficiency with which affix-triggered parsing proceeds, with higher OS readers resolving the parse more efficiently for complex nonwords and showing no corresponding effect for simple nonwords where no real affix is present.

The LP pattern requires a different account. Beyersmann et al. (2016) showed that readers higher in overall reading proficiency demonstrated embedded stem priming independent of affix status, suggesting that stem activation in skilled readers is not contingent on affix recognition. The present findings extend this observation by showing that it is specifically LP — depth and precision of lexical-semantic knowledge — rather than OS that drives stem-based parsing in the N250 data. High LP readers show a growing processing cost for simple nonwords across the LP range, driven entirely by the simple nonword trajectory while complex nonwords remain flat. This pattern is consistent with stem recognition triggering a morphological analysis attempt regardless of what follows, with the parse failing for simple nonwords because the pseudoaffix cannot be integrated into a valid morphological structure. The dissociation between OS and LP at the N250 therefore maps directly onto the distinction between affix-led and stem-led parsing: OS governs the efficiency of affix-triggered decomposition, while LP governs the propensity for stem-triggered morphological analysis independent of affix status.

This finding has implications for how morpho-orthographic decomposition accounts are framed. Current accounts treat early decomposition as a relatively uniform process driven primarily by affix recognition (Rastle and Davis, 2008), with individual differences not typically incorporated into the theoretical framework. The present results suggest that early parsing is not uniform across readers — it reflects at least two qualitatively distinct mechanisms that vary independently across individuals, one tied to orthographic sensitivity to affix structure and one tied to the depth of lexical-semantic knowledge in which stems are embedded.

4.4.3 Lexical Quality and the Role of LP at the N400

The N400 findings connect naturally to the Lexical Quality Hypothesis (Perfetti, 2007), under which more proficient readers have more precise and fully specified lexical representations involving tighter connections among orthographic, phonological, and semantic information. The three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction for nonwords is a particularly clear expression of this principle: the precision of lexical-semantic representations — indexed by LP — determines whether the semantic richness of a morphological family constitutes a processing burden or a processing advantage during novel form recognition. For low LP readers, a rich morphological neighbourhood creates semantic activation that cannot be efficiently organised against a novel form with no lexical entry, amplifying processing demands. For high LP readers, the same neighbourhood provides well-organised semantic knowledge that facilitates evaluation of the novel form, reducing processing demands. Representational precision therefore determines not just how fast semantic access proceeds but whether morphological richness helps or hinders it.

The word N400 finding — a crossover interaction between base frequency and LP — is also interpretable within this framework, though the mechanism is less precisely specified. LP modulates how base frequency contributes to N400 amplitude in a direction that changes across the LP range, consistent with LP determining how form-level familiarity interacts with the precision of lexical representations during semantic access. The nature of this modulation cannot be fully characterised from the present data alone, and accuracy data would be needed to adjudicate between possible accounts.

4.4.4 Limitations and Future Directions

Several limitations of the present study warrant acknowledgement.

First, the analyses were not pre-registered. The overall analytic strategy was theory-driven and specified in advance — including the symmetric model structure testing both OS and LP at each time window, and the primary predictions about OS at the N250 and LP at the N400. However, several secondary analytic decisions were made in response to patterns in the data, including the extension of follow-up contrasts to the observed limits of the LP and OS distributions, the choice of family size over base frequency as the nonword N250 covariate on empirical grounds, and the exploratory RT model examining Complexity $\times$ LP and Complexity $\times$ OS interactions. These decisions are documented and justified throughout, but the results should nonetheless be treated as requiring replication. Future studies should use the present findings to pre-specify the key analytic decisions before data collection, particularly the predicted three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction and the symmetric model structure at the N400.

Second, the word stimuli were not matched to the nonword stimuli on morphological variables, and the two stimulus sets are doing qualitatively different theoretical work — words index the time course of stored lexical representations while nonwords index generalisation to novel forms. Direct comparison of word and nonword findings therefore requires caution, and the theoretical claims developed here rest primarily on the nonword data.

Third, the Base Frequency $\times$ LP crossover at the N400 for words remains mechanistically underspecified. The present data are consistent with LP modulating how form-level familiarity contributes to semantic access, but the nature of that modulation — whether it reflects a shift in the depth of semantic engagement or a continuous change in how base frequency is weighted during access — cannot be determined from N400 amplitude alone. Accuracy data would be needed to characterise the mechanism more precisely, and future studies should collect both RT and accuracy measures to allow fuller interpretation of crossover interactions of this kind.

Fourth, the nonword stimuli were drawn from Sawi (2016) and may not generalise to other nonword sets. The affix-led versus stem-led parsing account developed here rests on the complex versus simple nonword contrast, which holds stem identity constant while manipulating suffix legitimacy. Future studies should replicate this contrast with independently constructed stimulus sets and should consider manipulating stem and affix properties orthogonally to provide more direct tests of the proposed mechanisms.

Fifth, the present sample consisted entirely of adult readers. The developmental trajectory of the OS/LP dissociation — when affix-led and stem-led parsing mechanisms become dissociable, and how this relates to the acquisition of morphological knowledge — remains an open question. Developmental studies examining the emergence of these individual difference effects across the school years would be a valuable extension of the present findings.

Finally, several key effects in the present study have small effect sizes, particularly the three-way Complexity $\times$ Family Size $\times$ LP interaction at the N400 ($\eta_p^2 = .001$). While the effect is theoretically

interpretable and statistically reliable, its small magnitude underscores the need for replication and suggests that future studies should be powered specifically to detect three-way interactions of this size. The present results provide the effect size estimates needed for such power calculations.

4.5 Figures

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Tables should be inserted at the end of the manuscript. Please build your table directly in LaTeX. Tables provided as jpeg/tiff files will not be accepted. Please note that very large tables (covering several pages) cannot be included in the final PDF for reasons of space. These tables will be published as Supplementary Material on the online article page at the time of acceptance. The author will be notified during the typesetting of the final article if this is the case.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare that the research was conducted in the absence of any commercial or financial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

JM: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Validation, Formal analysis, Resources, Data curation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Supervision. EK: Methodology, Software, Investigation, Data curation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Supervision. FG: Methodology, Software, Investigation, Data curation. JP: Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing TR: Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing EM: Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing CR-M: Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing NA: Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing

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SUPPLEMENTAL DATA

Supplementary Material should be uploaded separately on submission, if there are Supplementary Figures, please include the caption in the same file as the figure. LaTeX Supplementary Material templates can be found in the Frontiers LaTeX folder.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The datasets [GENERATED/ANALYZED] for this study can be found in the [NAME OF REPOSITORY] [LINK].

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